One of the few friends I gained in Princeton was a Russian student. We went on long strolls on the campus. I was surprised as much at his English —he spoke well—as his knowledge of thermodynamics. He had registered for a graduate programme under Professor Summerfield, who is considered a pioneer and a legend in solid propulsion systems.

After a few months of my wondering how he mastered so much on the subject even while doing the graduate programme, the Russian let me in to his little secret: He was a post-doctoral fellow. He was hiding his PhD just to experience Princeton, and work under Professor Summerfield.

I suspected there could be more. Russia, as much as the US, was known for deploying its people at centres of academic excellence to observe developments in strategic sectors. I did not ask him anything to clarify my suspicion; he was a knowledgeable friend I did not want to upset.

It was a usual practice for post-doctoral fellows of Princeton and Caltech, the two great US campuses of scientific research, to present their research/thesis on each other's campuses. This practice was more prevalent between Princeton's Guggenheim Laboratory for Aerospace Propulsion Systems and Caltech's Jet Propulsion Laboratory, both funded by NASA.

One day a Caltech researcher was presenting his research paper in Princeton, and I was there with the Russian friend. In the hall was William A Srignano, a Princeton professor.

The Caltech man went on for an hour explaining his paper, filling the blackboard with mathematical equations that looked like Greek to me. I was feeling lost, when the Russian leaned to me and whispered: 'This guy is bullshitting.'

'What?'

'His equations are fundamentally wrong,' said the Russian.

'Then why don't you question him.'

'No way.'

'Why?'

'I am not here to show off my knowledge.'

'No, you have to speak out. You can't let a wrong pass in such a gathering. It's against the spirit of science.'